

- RAG Learning

1.2 Historical Language Change

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 1 Language Variation

This topic covers how English has changed over time, with Edexcel's spec focusing on 1500 to the present. You need to know the **historical periods**, the **mechanisms** of change (semantic shift, neologisms, grammatical simplification), the **models** (S-curve, wave, random fluctuation, functional), and the **attitudes** (Aitchison, Crystal, Cameron vs prescriptivists).

Historical Periods of English



1.2.1 Historical Periods

Old English (c. 450–1066)

Germanic origins, complex inflectional system with four cases, distinctive runic and Latin-alphabet scripts. Largely unintelligible without study.

Middle English (1066–c. 1500)

Norman Conquest (1066) introduced massive French lexis — law, cuisine, warfare, fashion. Inflections simplified. Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* (c. 1400) shows a language recognisable but archaic.

Early Modern English (c. 1500–1700)

Caxton's printing press (1476) accelerated standardisation. The **Great Vowel Shift** (c. 1400–1700) changed long vowel sounds. Shakespeare's plays and the King James Bible (1611) are Early Modern. Thou/thee/thine coexisted with you/your until they gradually faded. Spelling began to stabilise.

Modern English (1700–present)

Johnson's *Dictionary* (1755) consolidated spelling and definitions. Colonisation spread English globally. Industrial Revolution added technical lexis. 20th century: broadcasting, global English, digital media. 21st century: internet-driven lexical change, new Englishes, inclusive forms.

1.2.2 Mechanisms of Change

Semantic change

Type	Description	Example
Broadening	Wider meaning	"Dog" (specific breed) → any canine
Narrowing	Narrower meaning	"Meat" (any food) → flesh
Amelioration	More positive	"Nice" ("foolish") → pleasant
Pejoration	More negative	"Silly" ("blessed") → foolish
Metaphorical shift	Literal → figurative	"Mouse" (animal) → computer input device
Weakening	Loss of force	"Awesome" once awe-inspiring → casual "very good"

Word-formation

Process	Example
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Affixation	un- + forget + -able → unforgettable
Compounding	laptop, bookshop
Blending	brunch (breakfast + lunch)
Clipping	exam (from examination)
Acronym / initialism	NATO (as a word); DIY (letters)
Eponym	sandwich (Earl of Sandwich); boycott
Borrowing	tsunami (Japanese); karaoke; barista (Italian)
Conversion	text (noun → verb); friend (noun → verb on social media)
Backformation	edit (from editor); burgle (from burglar)
Coinage	Kodak, Google (brand → generic)

Grammatical change

- Loss of thou/thee/thine (completed for everyday use by c. 1700).
- Re-emergence of singular **they** — attested since the 14th century and now standard.
- Expansion of modal-verb semantic ranges.
- Rise of progressive tense forms.
- Contracted forms ("don't", "won't") moving between registers.

1.2.3 Models of Change

S-curve (Labov)

Changes typically follow an S-shaped diffusion: slow initial uptake among innovators, rapid spread through the community, then plateau as the form approaches universality.

Wave theory (Bailey)

Innovation begins at an epicentre and spreads outward in waves, weakening with geographical and social distance. Explains why neighbouring regions share features.

Random fluctuation (Hockett)

Some change arises from unintentional variation, performance errors or chance adoption. Over time, some variants stabilise as norms. Limitation: cannot explain patterned sociolinguistic variation.

Functional theory (Halliday)

Language changes to meet the changing communicative needs of its users. New domains (technology, commerce, politics, identity) produce new lexis and registers. Functional motivation, not decay.

1.2.4 Attitudes — Aitchison vs Prescriptivism

Jean Aitchison's Reith Lectures (1996) critiqued three prescriptivist metaphors:

Metaphor	Claim	Aitchison's critique
Damp spoon	Change is caused by laziness	Most sound changes require more, not less, articulatory effort; "laziness" is moralising not linguistic
Crumbling castle	Language was once pure and is decaying	No "golden age" ever existed; English has always been varied
Infectious disease	Change spreads harmfully	Spread is a sign of social connection and communicative utility

Aitchison's position — shared by Crystal — is descriptivist: change is natural, systematic and often enriching. Complaints about decline reflect social anxiety (Cameron's "verbal hygiene") rather than linguistic fact.

1.2.5 Drivers of Change

- **Social contact and migration** — new vocabulary and grammar from contact languages.
- **Technology** — digital media producing "googled", "tweet", "swipe", "doomscroll"; new genres (tweet, meme).
- **Political and ideological change** — inclusive lexis, shifts in taboo.
- **Globalisation** — accelerated diffusion; pluricentric Englishes.
- **Prestige** — changes spread through prestigious groups.
- **Functional pressure** — adaptation to communicative needs.

1.2.6 Case Study — Digital Change

The last 25 years show accelerated lexical change tied to digital media. Crystal's work on "internet linguistics" argues digital communication is not ruining English but adding new registers:

- New lexis tied to digital practice: "doomscroll", "unfriend", "swipe".
- Graphological innovation: emoji as paralinguistic resource, creative capitalisation, ALL CAPS for shouting.
- Reanalysis of punctuation: the full stop acquiring pragmatic weight in digital chat.
- New genres: tweet, meme, TikTok caption — each with register conventions.

Research (Crystal, Tagg, Wood) shows digital mode does not replace standard writing ability in educated users — it adds a register.

Applied Example: The verb "to text" illustrates change perfectly. It began as a noun (text = written document). Through conversion, it became a verb (to text = send SMS). It then showed regular morphology in the past tense ("I texted you"). Each step illustrates a different mechanism — conversion, then regular inflection — all within two decades. A top-band answer links such examples to Halliday's functional theory.

1.2.7 How to Analyse Historical Change

1. Identify the **period** of the text(s).
2. Identify specific **changed features** — lexical, grammatical, graphological.
3. Classify the mechanism (broadening, narrowing, conversion, etc.).
4. Link to **model**: S-curve, wave, random fluctuation, functional.
5. Consider **context**: what social / technological / political drivers?
6. Evaluate **attitudes**: prescriptivist vs descriptivist interpretations.

Exam Tip: Edexcel Paper 1 pairs two texts with a historical gap. Include DATED examples alongside contemporary ones to demonstrate that change is continuous across 1500–present. Engaging with attitudes (Aitchison, Crystal, Cameron, prescriptivist voices) supports AO2 and AO3.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and illustrate: **broadening / narrowing / amelioration / pejoration / weakening, affixation, compounding, blending, clipping, acronym, eponym, borrowing, conversion, backformation, neologism, Great Vowel Shift, S-curve, wave theory, functional theory, random fluctuation, standardisation, golden age fallacy, verbal hygiene.** Figures: **Aitchison, Crystal, Hockett, Halliday, Labov, Bailey, Johnson (1755), Caxton (1476), Cameron.**